

YEAR  
2008



HEMANT CHAWLA

# The TIPPING Point

TRENDS & SOCIETY

By Dilip Bobb

*"I have held my ground as human history has unfolded in its timeless procession of laughter and tears, courage and cowardice, good and evil... I will prevail."*—Advertisement released by the Taj Hotel Group after the Mumbai terror attack.

As a metaphor for 2008, there could be none more appropriate, or depressing. The defining image of the year was the sight of that signature dome on fire, branded on the collective consciousness. That one visual summed up pride and heartbreak, anger and vulnerability but also defiance and resolve, reflected in the

advertisement and the nationwide public show of unity which followed. It may have, in the sum of its parts, been the year of fear but it was also a time when Indian society faced its moment of truth and transformation, when the twin threats of an economic crisis and personal security hit Indian society where it hurts the most: in

the pocket and in the mind.

At no other time in recent memory has Indian society seemed so vulnerable. No one was insulated, from the man in the street to the rich and famous in five star environs and boardrooms, all become common targets. Of the double-barrelled threats, which was the more serious is a question to which there